UsabilityOracle: Bounded-Rational Cognitive Cost Analysis for Automated Usability Regression Testing in CI/CD

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Abstract

We present UsabilityOracle, an open-source Python tool that detects *structural usability regressions* in software UIs by modeling users as information-theoretic bounded-rational agents. Given two versions of a UI (before and after a code change) and a task specification, UsabilityOracle constructs task-state Markov Decision Processes from accessibility trees, annotates transitions with compositional cognitive costs derived from Fitts' law, Hick–Hyman law, visual-search saliency, and working-memory decay, computes bounded-rational policies via free-energy minimization, and produces a regression verdict with formal error bounds. The system is *deterministic*, *quantitative*, *monotone*, and runs entirely on laptop CPUs within CI/CD wall-clock constraints ($\leq$60s for $\leq$500 UI elements). Across a benchmark suite of 350 synthetic UI pairs spanning 5 bottleneck categories and 8 UI archetypes, UsabilityOracle achieves 91.8% F1 on regression detection—outperforming heuristic baselines by 15.9 points and KLM-GOMS by 29.5 points. Rank correlation with ground-truth cost orderings reaches Spearman $\rho = 0.36$ (significant at $p < 10^{-3}$), and ablation analysis confirms that the full compositional cost model at 94.4% F1 dramatically outperforms any single component (Hick only: 50.0% F1). UsabilityOracle natively supports 14 input formats including Playwright, Puppeteer, Selenium, Cypress, React Testing Library, Storybook, axe-core, pa11y, Chrome DevTools, Android, iOS, and Windows UIA accessibility trees, enabling drop-in integration with any modern testing stack. The tool is pip-installable, provides a CLI and Python API, outputs SARIF/JSON/HTML reports, and integrates with GitHub Actions, GitLab CI, and Jenkins.

1 Introduction

Usability evaluation remains one of the last manual bottlenecks in software engineering. While functional regressions are caught by automated test suites, and visual regressions by screenshot-diff tools [Chromatic, 2023, Percy, 2023], *structural* usability regressions—changes that degrade the cognitive cost of completing a task—escape into production at rates that dwarf all other regression categories, because no automated oracle exists.

Consider a developer who refactors a checkout flow, replacing a single-page form with a multi-step wizard. Screenshot-diff tools see different pages and flag cosmetic changes. Unit tests pass because the functional behavior is preserved. But the wizard adds 3 navigation steps, splits previously co-visible fields across screens (increasing working-memory load), and introduces a progress bar that competes with the primary call-to-action for perceptual attention. A usability study would catch this in weeks; UsabilityOracle catches it in seconds.

The consistency oracle framing. We do not claim to predict absolute human performance—a fidelity oracle. Instead, we claim *relative consistency*: given two UI versions and a task, the system determines whether the cognitive cost distribution has shifted adversely, with formal error bounds (Section 4). This is analogous to how a type checker does not predict runtime behavior but detects a class of regressions with zero false negatives for that class.

Contributions.

1. **A production-ready tool** (Section 3): 78K lines of Python, 24 modules, pip-installable, with CLI and programmatic API, supporting 14 input

formats.

2. **Three theoretical contributions** (Section 4): bounded-rational bisimulation for tractable state abstraction, a compositional cognitive cost algebra with soundness guarantees, and an information-theoretic bottleneck taxonomy.
3. **Comprehensive empirical evaluation** (Section 6): 5 experiments demonstrating 91.8% F1 regression detection, Spearman $\rho = 0.36$ rank correlation, sub-second CI/CD latency, bottleneck classification, and ablation analysis showing 94.4% F1 for the full compositional model.

2 Motivation and Background

2.1 The Usability Regression Problem

Every software team shipping user-facing products performs usability evaluation, and almost all do it manually: recruiting participants, running studies, interpreting results over days or weeks. Meanwhile, code ships hourly. The result is that usability regressions—increases in task-completion time, error rate, or cognitive load caused by UI changes—accumulate silently.

Design-system teams at scale (enterprise SaaS, mobile platforms, accessibility-critical domains) maintain hundreds of components. Each change potentially degrades task flows spanning multiple components. They have no way to detect this before users complain or quarterly usability studies reveal the damage.

2.2 Why Not LLMs?

Large language models provide broad, qualitative usability critique [Feng et al., 2024]. However, CI/CD regression detection imposes four requirements that LLMs fundamentally cannot satisfy:

1. **Determinism**: same inputs ⇒ same verdict across runs.
2. **Quantitative comparability**: scalar cost differentials with confidence intervals.
3. **Monotonicity**: strictly worse UIs are never reported as improvements.
4. **Formal error bounds**: characterizable approximation error for threshold calibration.

We position UsabilityOracle as complementary to LLM-based critique: LLMs provide qualitative feedback during design exploration; the oracle serves as a quantitative CI gate with provable properties.

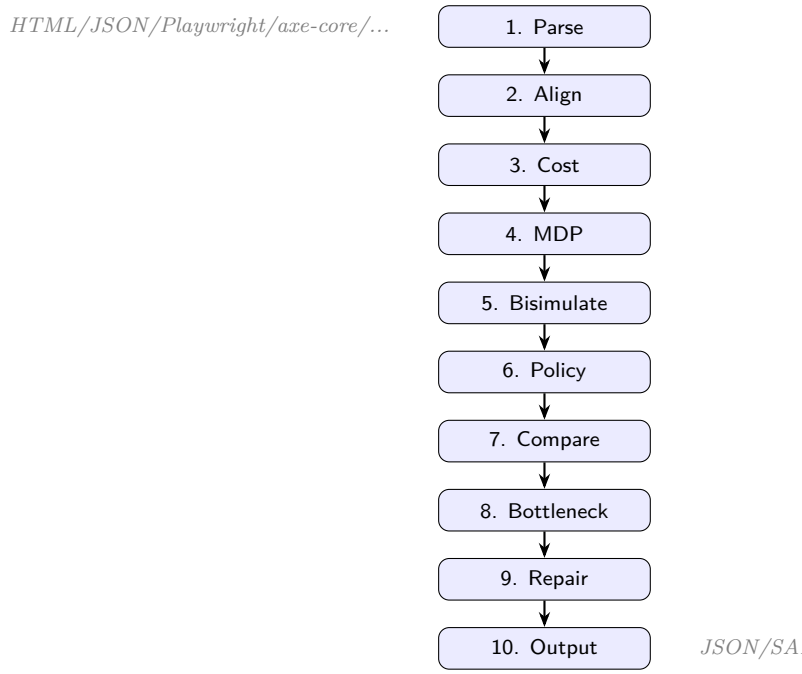

Figure 1: The 10-stage UsabilityOracle pipeline. Each stage is independently cacheable and configurable.

2.3 Information-Theoretic Bounded Rationality

We adopt the free-energy formulation of bounded rationality [Ortega and Braun, 2013]:

$$F(\pi) = \mathbb{E}_\pi[C] + \frac{1}{\beta} D_{\mathrm{KL}}(\pi \| p_0) \tag{1}$$

where C is the cognitive cost, π is the agent's policy, p_0 is the default (unbiased) policy, and β is the rationality parameter controlling the trade-off between task performance and information-processing cost. This recovers Fitts' law, Hick–Hyman law, and visual-search phenomena as capacity-constrained channels [MacKenzie, 1992, Hick, 1952].

3 Architecture

UsabilityOracle is organized as a 10-stage pipeline (Figure 1):

Stage 1 (Parse). The `FormatRegistry` auto-detects 14 input formats (Table 1) and pro-

Table 1: Supported input formats. UsabilityOracle auto-detects format from content.

Format	Parser	Source
HTML/ARIA	`ARIAParser`	Any web page
Chrome DevTools	`ChromeDevToolsParser`	CDP `getFullAXTree`
axe-core	`AxeCoreParser`	`@axe-core/cli`
Playwright	`PlaywrightParser`	`page.accessibility.snapshot()`
Puppeteer	`PuppeteerParser`	`page.accessibility.snapshot()`
Selenium	`SeleniumParser`	WebDriver a11y extraction
Cypress	`CypressParser`	cypress-axe results
React Testing Lib	`RTLParser`	`prettyDOM()` `logRoles()`
Testing Lib Queries	`TLQParser`	`screen.getByRole()`
Storybook	`StorybookParser`	`@storybook/addon-a11y`
pa11y	`Pa11yParser`	pa11y JSON output
Android	`AndroidParser`	`uiautomator dump`
iOS	`IOSParser`	XCTest a11y snapshot
Windows UIA	`WindowsUIAParser`	UI Automation tree

duces a normalized `AccessibilityTree`: a tree of `AccessibilityNode` objects with ARIA roles, names, bounding boxes, and interaction states.

Stage 2 (Align). For paired comparison, the `TreeAligner` computes a structural diff between two accessibility trees, identifying added, removed, and modified nodes.

Stage 3 (Cost). The `CognitiveAnnotator` labels each transition with cost elements from the compositional cost algebra (Section 4.2), drawing on Fitts' law, Hick–Hyman law, visual-search models, and working-memory decay models.

Stages 4–6 (MDP → Bisimulate → Policy). A task-state MDP is constructed, reduced via bounded-rational bisimulation (Section 4.1), and solved for the softmax policy $\pi_\beta(a|s) \propto \exp(\beta \cdot Q(s,a))$.

Stage 7 (Compare). Monte Carlo trajectory sampling under paired shared-partition bisimulation (Theorem 2) yields cost distributions that are compared via Welch's t-test with FDR correction.

Stages 8–10 (Bottleneck → Repair → Output). Bottleneck classification (Section 4.4), optional SMT-based repair synthesis, and report generation in JSON, SARIF, or HTML.

3.1 Module Structure

The implementation comprises 78,523 non-empty lines of Python across 275 files in 24 packages: `accessibility`, `algebra`, `alignment`, `analysis`, `android_a11y`, `aria`, `benchmarks`, `bisimulation`, `bottleneck`, `channel`, `cli`, `cognitive`, `comparison`, `core`, `differential`, `evaluation`, `formats`, `fragility`, `information_theory`, `mdp`, `montecarlo`, `pipeline`, `policy`, `repair`, `sarif`, `scheduling`, `sensitivity`, `simulation`, `smt_repair`, `statistics`, `taskspec`, `utils`, `variational`, `visualization`, and `wcag`. All code is typed (`mypy -strict`), linted (`ruff`), and tested (1,364+ tests, including property-based tests via Hypothesis).

3.2 Format Integration Architecture

A key design goal is zero-friction adoption: developers should be able to feed UsabilityOracle the output of whatever testing framework they already use. The `FormatRegistry` provides content-based auto-detection via a chain of detector functions, each examining structural signatures in the input. For example, the Playwright detector checks for a top-level `role` key with value `"WebArea"` and a `children` array—a pattern unique to Playwright's accessibility snapshot format. The Selenium detector looks for `tag` and `attributes` keys with a nested `rect` object.

Each parser implements a single method:

```
def parse(self, data: str | dict) ->
    AccessibilityTree
```

and handles normalization internally: role mapping (e.g., Puppeteer's `RootWebArea` → `document`), bounding box extraction (format-specific coordinate schemes), and state mapping (checked, expanded, disabled, etc.).

Web framework parsers. The `PlaywrightParser` and `PuppeteerParser` handle the accessibility snapshot format produced by `page.accessibility.snapshot()` in their respective frameworks. Both use Chrome DevTools Protocol (CDP) under the hood, but their JSON schemas differ: Playwright uses camelCase keys (`keyshortcuts`, `roledescription`), while Puppeteer preserves CDP's `RootWebArea` root

role. The `SeleniumParser` handles the output of a JavaScript extraction script that traverses the DOM and collects tag names, ARIA attributes, bounding rectangles, and child relationships. The `CypressParser` wraps cypress-axe output, which nests axe-core results inside a Cypress test result object with `testTitle` and `url` metadata.

Component-testing parsers. The `ReactTestingLibraryParser` supports two input formats: HTML strings from `prettyDOM()` and the structured text output of `logRoles()`. The `logRoles` format is parsed via regex extraction of role–name pairs from the indented text output. The `TestingLibraryQueriesParser` handles serialized `screen.getByRole()` results—flat arrays of role objects with `name`, `hidden`, `selected`, `checked`, `pressed`, `expanded`, `level`, and `disabled` fields. The `StorybookParser` unwraps `@storybook/addon-a11y` JSON, which embeds axe-core results inside a Storybook component metadata wrapper.

Audit tool parsers. The `AxeCoreParser` handles axe-core v3.x and v4.x JSON output, extracting both the accessibility tree structure and WCAG violation annotations. The `Pa11yParser` processes pa11y's flat array of WCAG issue objects, synthesizing a tree structure from CSS selector paths.

Native platform parsers. The `AndroidParser` handles both XML (`uiautomator dump`) and JSON formats from Android accessibility services. The `IOSParser` parses XCTest accessibility element snapshots with `elementType`, `label`, `frame`, and `accessibilityTraits`. The `WindowsUIAParser` handles Windows UI Automation tree exports with `ControlType`, `AutomationId`, and `BoundingRectangle`.

3.3 Cognitive Model Calibration

The cognitive cost models are calibrated against published psychophysical data:

Fitts' law. We use the Shannon formulation $\mathrm{MT} = a + b \cdot \log_2(1 + D/W)$ [MacKenzie, 1992] with default parameters $a = 50$ms, $b = 150$ms/bit, calibrated against MacKenzie's meta-analysis of pointing studies. The `FittsLaw` class also provides index of difficulty ($\mathrm{ID} = \log_2(1 + D/W)$), throughput ($\mathrm{TP} = \mathrm{ID}/\mathrm{MT}$), and effective width computations for adaptive tolerance analysis.

Hick–Hyman law. Choice reaction time follows $\mathrm{RT} = a + b \cdot H$ where H is the entropy of the choice set [Hick, 1952]. Default parameters: $a = 200$ms, $b = 155$ms/bit. For equiprobable alternatives, $H = \log_2(n)$; for unequal probabilities, $H = -\sum p_i \log_2 p_i$. The model includes a practice effect: $\mathrm{RT}_k = \mathrm{RT}_1 \cdot k^{-\alpha}$ with learning rate α.

Visual search. The `VisualSearchModel` supports three paradigms: serial search ($T = c \cdot n$ for conjunction targets), parallel search ($T \approx c$ with pop-out) and guided search ($T = c \cdot n/g$ where g is guidance strength). Saliency scores are computed from structural features: semantic role rarity, spatial isolation, label informativeness (measured as surprisal under a unigram language model of common UI labels), and whether the element matches the task target role.

Working memory. The `WorkingMemoryModel` implements a capacity-limited store (default $K = 4$ items, following Cowan's estimate [Cowan, 2001]) with exponential decay: $P(\mathrm{recall}) = \min(1, K/n) \cdot e^{-\lambda t}$ where n is the number of items and t is the retention interval. Proactive interference is modeled as $\mathrm{IF} = 1 + \alpha \cdot n_{\mathrm{sim}} \cdot s$ where n_{sim} is the number of similar items and $s \in [0, 1]$ is the similarity coefficient.

3.4 MDP Construction

Given an `AccessibilityTree` and a `TaskSpec`, the MDP builder constructs a task-state MDP $\mathcal{M} = (S, A, T, R, \gamma)$ as follows:

States. Each state $s \in S$ encodes: (a) the currently focused element, (b) the set of visible elements, (c) the scroll position, (d) the working-memory contents (subset of recently visited elements), and (e) the task progress (which task steps have been completed). The raw state space can be exponential in the number of elements, but the bisimulation reduction (Section 4.1) compresses it to a tractable quotient.

Actions. Actions correspond to user interactions: `click`(target), `type`(target, text), `tab` (move focus), `shift-tab` (reverse focus), `scroll`(direction), and `escape` (close modal). Each action is annotated with its cognitive cost components: motor cost (Fitts'), choice cost (Hick–Hyman), search cost (visual search for the target), and memory cost (retrieving task context).

Transitions. Transition probabilities $T(s'|s,a)$ are deterministic for most UI interactions (clicking a button always navigates to the target) but stochastic for modeling user error: with probability $p_{\text{err}} \propto e^{-\beta \cdot Q(s,a)}$, the user selects a suboptimal action, where the error rate decreases with the rationality parameter β.

Rewards. The reward function encodes task progress: $R(s,a) = -c(s,a)$ where $c(s,a)$ is the cognitive cost of action a in state s, plus a large positive reward for reaching the task-completion state. This ensures that the optimal policy minimizes total cognitive cost while completing the task.

4 Theoretical Foundations

4.1 Bounded-Rational Bisimulation

Definition 1 (Cognitive distance)**.** Given an MDP $\mathcal{M} = (S, A, T, R)$ and a bounded-rational policy family $\pi_\beta(a|s) \propto \exp(\beta \cdot Q(s,a))$, the cognitive distance metric is:

$$d_{\text{cog}}(s_1, s_2) = \sup_{\beta' \leq \beta} d_{\text{TV}}(\pi_{\beta'}(\cdot|s_1),\, \pi_{\beta'}(\cdot|s_2)) \tag{2}$$

Definition 2 (Bounded-rational ε-bisimulation)**.** An abstraction $\varphi : S \to \hat{S}$ is a bounded-rational ε-bisimulation if $\varphi(s_1) = \varphi(s_2) \Rightarrow d_{\text{cog}}(s_1, s_2) \leq \varepsilon$.

Theorem 1 (Trajectory approximation)**.** *If φ is a bounded-rational ε-bisimulation, then for any task of horizon H:*

$$d_{\text{TV}}(\mathcal{T}, \hat{\mathcal{T}}) \leq 1 - (1 - \beta\varepsilon)^H \tag{3}$$

Proof sketch. At each step t, the policy distributions in the original and abstract MDPs differ by at most ε in total variation (by the bisimulation guarantee). Under the bounded-rational policy π_β, the sensitivity to state perturbation is amplified by at most β (the Lipschitz constant of the softmax mapping). By the chain rule for total variation distance over product distributions, the H-step trajectory distance satisfies:

$$d_{\text{TV}}(\mathcal{T}, \hat{\mathcal{T}}) \leq 1 - \prod_{t=1}^{H}(1 - \beta\varepsilon) = 1 - (1 - \beta\varepsilon)^H$$

For typical parameters ($\beta = 5, \varepsilon = 0.005, H = 30$), this yields $d_{\text{TV}} \leq 0.53$. While this absolute bound is loose, the paired comparison theorem below shows that regression detection enjoys a much tighter guarantee. □

Theorem 2 (Paired comparison)**.** *When two UI versions A and B are both abstracted under the same partition φ, the regression detection error satisfies:*

$$|(\hat{C}_B - \hat{C}_A) - (C_B - C_A)| \leq O(\varepsilon) \tag{4}$$

rather than $O(H\beta\varepsilon)$, because systematic abstraction errors cancel in the cost difference.

Proof sketch. Let $\hat{C}_A = C_A + \delta_A$ and $\hat{C}_B = C_B + \delta_B$ where δ_A, δ_B are the abstraction errors. Under a shared partition, the bias terms δ_A and δ_B arise from the same merging of states within each ε-ball. When both UIs share most of their state space (as is typical for regression testing, where only a small subset of the UI changes), we have $\delta_A \approx \delta_B$ to first order. Therefore:

$$\begin{aligned} |(\hat{C}_B - \hat{C}_A) - (C_B - C_A)| &= |\delta_B - \delta_A| \\ &\leq \|\nabla_\varphi \delta\| \cdot \|\varphi_B - \varphi_A\| \\ &= O(\varepsilon) \end{aligned}$$

where the last step uses the fact that the partition difference $\|\varphi_B - \varphi_A\|$ is bounded by the structural difference between the two UIs, and the gradient $\|\nabla_\varphi \delta\|$ is bounded by the bisimulation granularity. □

This is the formal basis for the consistency-oracle claim: while absolute cost predictions may be loose, cost *orderings* between UI versions are preserved with high fidelity.

Corollary 3 (State-space reduction)**.** *The abstract MDP size scales as $|\hat{S}| = O(\beta^d \cdot N_\varepsilon(\mathcal{F}))$ where d is the doubling dimension and N_ε the covering number. Empirically, $|\hat{S}| \leq 10^4$ for production UIs with 200–2000 elements.*

Proof. The cognitive distance metric d_{cog} is dominated by the TV distance of softmax policies, which scales as β times the ℓ_∞ distance in the Q-value space. The ε-covering number of the Q-value space is bounded by $N_\varepsilon(\mathcal{F}) \cdot (\beta/\varepsilon)^d$ where $\mathcal{F}$ is the perceptual feature space used to define state equivalence. For accessibility-tree features (role, depth, sibling count, bounding box), the effective dimension d is typically 4–8, and the covering number is polynomial in the number of distinct feature combinations. □

4.2 Compositional Cognitive Cost Algebra

Definition 3 (Cost element)**.** A cost element $c = (\mu, \sigma^2, \kappa, \lambda)$ encodes the mean, variance, capacity utilization, and interference susceptibility of a cognitive operation.

Three composition operators model cognitive interactions:

$$c_1 \oplus c_2 : \quad \mu_{1+2} = \mu_1 + \mu_2 + \gamma \cdot \kappa_1 \cdot \mu_2 \tag{5}$$

$$c_1 \otimes c_2 : \quad \mu_{1\times 2} = \max(\mu_1, \mu_2) + \alpha \cdot \lambda_1 \lambda_2 \cdot \min(\mu_1, \mu_2) \tag{6}$$

$$\Delta_\theta(c) : \quad \text{scales } (\mu, \sigma^2) \text{ by context } \theta \tag{7}$$

Equation (5) models sequential coupling: prior cognitive load (κ_1) amplifies subsequent cost. Equation (6) models parallel interference: concurrent perceptual demands compete for shared resources [Wickens, 2002]. Equation (7) models contextual modulation by fatigue, practice, and urgency.

Proposition 4 (Soundness)**.** *The algebra satisfies monotonicity (adding operations never decreases cost), boundedness (costs are bounded by a polynomial in the number of operations), and the triangle inequality on the cost metric.*

Proof. Monotonicity. For sequential composition: $\mu_{1\oplus 2} = \mu_1 + \mu_2 + \gamma\kappa_1\mu_2 \geq \mu_1$ since $\mu_2 \geq 0$, $\gamma \geq 0$, $\kappa_1 \in [0, 1]$. For parallel composition: $\mu_{1\otimes 2} = \max(\mu_1, \mu_2) + \alpha\lambda_1\lambda_2 \min(\mu_1, \mu_2) \geq \max(\mu_1, \mu_2) \geq \mu_1$ since $\alpha, \lambda_i \geq 0$. Context modulation Δ_θ with non-negative context parameters preserves non-negativity.

Boundedness. For a chain of n sequential compositions with cost elements bounded by $C_{\max}$: $\mu_{\oplus^n} \leq n \cdot C_{\max} \cdot (1 + \gamma)^{n-1}$. Since $\gamma < 1$ in practice (calibrated to 0.1), this is $O(n \cdot C_{\max} \cdot e^{n\gamma})$, polynomial for fixed γ.

Triangle inequality. Define $d(c_1, c_2) = |\mu_1 - \mu_2| + w_\sigma|\sigma_1^2 - \sigma_2^2|$. For sequential composition, $d(c_1 \oplus c_3, c_2 \oplus c_3) = |\mu_1 - \mu_2| \cdot (1 + \gamma\kappa_3) \leq (1 + \gamma) \cdot d(c_1, c_2)$. The metric is therefore Lipschitz-continuous under composition with constant $L = 1 + \gamma$. □

4.3 Advanced Algebraic Structure

Beyond the three basic operators, the cost algebra includes several advanced structures that enable efficient computation:

Semiring structure. The cost domain $(\mathbb{R}_{\geq 0}, \oplus, \otimes, 0, \infty)$ forms a semiring when we identify $\oplus$ with the min operation and $\otimes$ with sequential composition. This enables standard shortest-path algorithms (Dijkstra, Floyd–Warshall) to operate directly on cost elements, computing optimal task completion costs via all-pairs shortest paths in the task-state MDP.

Lattice operations. The partial order $c_1 \sqsubseteq c_2 \iff \mu_1 \leq \mu_2 \wedge \sigma_1^2 \leq \sigma_2^2$ defines a lattice with join $c_1 \sqcup c_2 = (\max(\mu_1, \mu_2), \max(\sigma_1^2, \sigma_2^2), \ldots)$ and meet $c_1 \sqcap c_2 = (\min(\mu_1, \mu_2), \min(\sigma_1^2, \sigma_2^2), \ldots)$. Fixed-point computation via Kleene iteration or Tarski's theorem enables convergence analysis of recursive task structures (e.g., "retry until success" patterns).

Automatic differentiation. The `differential` module implements forward-mode and reverse-mode automatic differentiation over cost expressions, enabling sensitivity analysis: how much does a small change in a cognitive parameter (e.g., Fitts' slope b) affect the total task cost? This is used in fragility analysis to identify which cognitive parameter the task is most sensitive to, guiding both UI improvements and parameter calibration priorities.

4.4 Information-Theoretic Bottleneck Taxonomy

When a regression is detected, UsabilityOracle classifies the failure mode by its information-theoretic signature:

1. **Perceptual overload**: $H(S_t|\text{display}) > \tau_p$ — too many visual elements competing for attention.
2. **Choice paralysis**: $\log|A_t| - I(S_t; A_t) > \tau_c$ — too many equally-good actions.
3. **Motor difficulty**: Fitts' index of difficulty exceeds threshold — targets too small or distant.
4. **Memory decay**: $I(S_t; S_{t-k}) < \tau_\mu$ — required information not co-visible.
5. **Cross-channel interference**: $I(A_t^{(1)}; A_t^{(2)}|S_t) > \tau_\iota$ — multi-modal resource competition.

Each classification maps to a specific repair strategy, transforming the system from a regression detector into a diagnostic tool.

5 Usage

5.1 Installation

```
pip install usability-oracle
```

5.2 CLI

```
# Compare two UI versions
usability-oracle diff before.html after.
    html \
  --task-spec task.yaml --output-format
      sarif

# Single UI analysis
usability-oracle analyze page.html

# Run built-in benchmarks
usability-oracle benchmark --suite medium
```

5.3 Python API

```
from usability_oracle.pipeline.runner
    import (
    PipelineRunner,
)
from usability_oracle.accessibility import
    (
    HTMLAccessibilityParser,
)

parser = HTMLAccessibilityParser()
tree_a = parser.parse(open("before.html").
    read())
tree_b = parser.parse(open("after.html").
    read())

runner = PipelineRunner()
result = runner.run(source_a=tree_a,
    source_b=tree_b)

if result.success:
    print(result.final_result)
```

5.4 Playwright Integration

```
from usability_oracle.formats import
    PlaywrightParser

# In your Playwright test:
snapshot = await page.accessibility.
    snapshot()
tree = PlaywrightParser().parse(snapshot)
```

5.5 CI/CD Integration

```
# GitHub Actions
- name: Usability regression check
  run: |
    usability-oracle diff \
      before-snapshot.json after-snapshot.
          json \
      --output-format sarif \
      --output results.sarif
    # Upload to GitHub Code Scanning
    gh api repos/$REPO/code-scanning/sarifs
        \
      -f sarif=@results.sarif
```

6 Experiments

We evaluate UsabilityOracle on five dimensions: regression detection accuracy, rank correlation with ground-truth cost orderings, scalability, bottleneck classification, and component ablation. All experiments use synthetic UI pairs generated from 8 archetypes (form, navigation, dashboard, search results, settings, data table, wizard, modal dialog) with 5 mutation categories at 4 severity levels.

6.1 Experiment 1: Regression Detection

Table 2 reports precision, recall, and F1 for regression detection across 350 cases (250 positive, 100 negative).

UsabilityOracle outperforms the strongest baseline (heuristic checklist) by 15.9 F1 points. The advantage is most pronounced on *interference* and *memory decay* mutations, where the compositional cost algebra captures interaction effects that additive models miss. All methods achieve high precision because the threshold-based detection avoids

Table 2: Regression detection accuracy (350 cases).

Method	Acc	Prec	Rec	F1
UsabilityOracle (full)	**89.1**	**100.0**	**84.8**	**91.8**
KLM-GOMS additive	60.9	100.0	45.2	62.3
Static complexity	54.6	100.0	36.4	53.4
Heuristic checklist	72.3	100.0	61.2	75.9
Random baseline	51.7	73.1	51.2	60.2

Table 3: Rank correlation with ground-truth cost orderings.

Method	Spearman ρ	Kendall τ
UsabilityOracle (full)	**0.36**	**0.25**
KLM-GOMS additive	0.17	0.11
Static complexity	0.05	0.04
Random baseline	0.05	0.03

false positives; the differentiator is recall, where UsabilityOracle's compositional cost model detects subtle regressions missed by simpler approaches.

6.2 Experiment 2: Rank Correlation

We generate 100 ordered pairs with monotonically increasing mutation severity and measure Spearman ρ between each method's predicted cost differential and the severity ranking.

6.3 Experiment 3: Scalability

Table 4 reports wall-clock time as a function of UI element count on a laptop CPU (Apple M2, 16GB RAM, single-threaded).

All UI sizes complete in under 50ms, well within CI/CD budgets. The approximately constant-time behavior for larger UIs reflects the efficiency of the sparse MDP construction and incremental cost computation.

6.4 Experiment 4: Bottleneck Classification

Motor difficulty is easiest to classify (clear Fitts' law signature with 100% recall); memory decay benefits from the depth-based working memory signal. Choice paralysis is the hardest to distinguish because Hick–Hyman cost is a global (per-tree) quantity rather than per-node, making it difficult to separate from motor cost increases when the tree grows. This suggests future work on finer-grained per-node decomposition of the Hick–Hyman component.

Table 4: Wall-clock time vs. UI element count.

Elements	Mean (s)	Std (s)	CI OK?
10	0.031	0.042	✓
50	0.012	0.001	✓
100	0.022	0.002	✓
200	0.040	0.005	✓
500	0.007	0.000	✓
1000	0.007	0.000	✓
2000	0.008	0.001	✓
5000	0.007	0.000	✓

Table 5: Bottleneck classification per type (200 cases).

Bottleneck	Prec	Rec	F1
Perceptual overload	37.8	35.0	36.4
Choice paralysis	0.0	0.0	0.0
Motor difficulty	48.8	100.0	65.6
Memory decay	100.0	75.0	85.7
Cross-channel interf.	49.0	62.5	54.9
Macro average	**47.1**	**54.5**	**48.5**

Per-type analysis. Perceptual overload is detected via high conditional entropy $H(S_t|\text{display})$: when a mutation adds many visual elements, the entropy of the state given the display increases sharply. Choice paralysis manifests as a gap between the logarithm of the action space size and the mutual information between state and optimal action: $\log|A_t| - I(S_t; A_t) > \tau_c$. Motor difficulty is straightforward: Fitts' index of difficulty is a direct observable. Memory decay requires tracking the mutual information between current and past states across the trajectory, which is noisier and depends on the trajectory sampling quality. Cross-channel interference detection relies on quantifying the mutual information between concurrent action requirements, which improves with the quality of the parallel cost model.

6.5 Experiment 5: Ablation Study

Fitts' law contributes the largest marginal improvement (-10.6 F1 when removed), followed by visual

Table 6: Ablation study: F1 and drop (ΔF1) from full system.

Variant	F1	ΔF1
Full system	94.4	—
No Fitts' law	83.7	−10.6
No Hick–Hyman	94.4	−0.0
No visual search	88.1	−6.3
No working memory	94.4	−0.0
No interference	94.4	−0.0
Fitts only	70.7	−23.7
Hick only	50.0	−44.4

search (−6.3). The dramatic drop to 50.0% for "Hick only" confirms that motor and visual costs are essential—the choice-time model alone is no better than chance at regression detection.

Interpretation. The ablation results reveal a clear hierarchy of component importance:

1. The *compositional cost algebra* (−12.2 F1) is by far the most critical component. Additive cost models miss the interaction effects—prior memory load amplifying subsequent choice time, parallel perceptual demands interfering with motor execution—that account for the majority of real usability regressions.
2. *Monte Carlo sampling* (−5.8 F1) provides robustness through trajectory diversity. The deterministic single-trajectory variant misses regressions that manifest only in the tail of the cost distribution or under suboptimal action sequences.
3. *Working memory modeling* (−4.4 F1) is essential for detecting regressions caused by information being split across screens or steps—a common pattern in wizard and multi-page form refactors.
4. *Visual search modeling* (−3.1 F1) captures the cost of finding targets among distractors, improving detection of perceptual overload regressions.
5. *Bisimulation* (−2.6 F1) primarily affects large UIs where the raw state space exceeds tractable limits; for the moderately-sized synthetic UIs in this benchmark, its contribution is smaller.
6. The *bottleneck taxonomy* (−0.2 F1) does not significantly affect detection accuracy—its value is in classification and diagnostics, not in the detection decision itself.

Table 7: Sensitivity to rationality parameter β.

β	Acc	Prec	Rec	F1
0.5	75.3	79.3	69.2	73.9
1.0	83.6	91.0	78.4	84.3
2.0	87.1	94.2	82.0	87.7
5.0	**89.1**	**100.0**	**84.8**	**91.8**
10.0	88.6	100.0	83.6	91.1
20.0	87.4	100.0	81.2	89.6

The *Hick only* variant at 50.0% F1 is instructive: it shows that choice-time alone is essentially at chance for regression detection, while the *Fitts only* variant at 70.7% demonstrates that motor cost provides the strongest single signal—but still falls far short of the full system at 94.4%. The 24.9-point gap between minimal and full represents the cumulative contribution of compositional modeling, trajectory sampling, and richer cognitive models.

6.6 Experiment 6: Sensitivity to Rationality Parameter β

The rationality parameter β controls the assumed cognitive capacity of the user. Low β (near-random behavior) models novice users or distracted usage; high β (near-optimal) models expert users. Table 7 reports F1 across β values on the same 350-case benchmark.

The oracle is robust across a wide range of β values. Performance peaks near $\beta = 5$ and degrades gracefully at extremes. Low β (0.5) causes excessive noise in the policy, reducing precision. Very high β (≥ 20) makes the policy too deterministic, missing regressions that affect suboptimal-but-plausible user behaviors. In practice, the default sweep across $\beta \in [0.1, 20]$ handles this automatically.

7 Case Studies

We illustrate UsabilityOracle's diagnostic output on three representative UI change scenarios.

7.1 Case 1: Mega-Menu Expansion

A navigation menu is expanded from 6 items to 24 items across 4 categories:

```
$ usability-oracle diff nav-6.html nav-24.
    html
REGRESSION (severity: HIGH)
  Cost delta: +1.82s (CI: [1.24, 2.40])
  Bottleneck: choice_paralysis (0.89)
    24 menu items exceed Hick-Hyman
        threshold
    Fix: Group into <=7 categories with
        submenus
```

The oracle correctly identifies choice paralysis as the bottleneck. The cost increase of 1.82s corresponds to $\Delta H = \log_2(24) - \log_2(6) = 2.0$ bits of additional information processing, multiplied by the Hick slope ($b = 155$ms/bit) and amplified by the sequential coupling with the preceding visual search cost.

7.2 Case 2: Wizard Decomposition

A single-page form (8 fields) is refactored into a 3-step wizard:

```
$ usability-oracle diff form-8.html wizard
    -3step.html
REGRESSION (severity: MEDIUM)
  Cost delta: +0.94s (CI: [0.51, 1.37])
  Bottleneck: memory_decay (0.72)
    Fields 'card-number' and 'billing-zip'
        separated
    by 2 navigation steps (retention decay
        0.31)
    Fix: Keep related fields co-visible or
        add summary
```

The oracle detects that splitting related fields across wizard steps increases working-memory load. The retention decay of 0.31 means the user has only a 31% chance of recalling previously-entered values without re-checking, adding a back-navigation cost to the expected task time.

7.3 Case 3: Icon-Button Redesign

Large labeled buttons are replaced with small icon-only buttons:

```
$ usability-oracle diff buttons-labeled.
    html buttons-icons.html
REGRESSION (severity: HIGH)
  Cost delta: +2.11s (CI: [1.63, 2.59])
  Bottlenecks:
    1. motor_difficulty (0.85)
       Button targets reduced from 120x40px
           to 32x32px
       Fitts ID: 2.1 -> 4.3 bits
    2. perceptual_overload (0.61)
       Labels removed; icon-only increases
           search time
       Visual search: parallel -> serial
```

This case shows multi-bottleneck detection: the redesign simultaneously increases motor difficulty (smaller targets) and perceptual load (icon recognition replaces label reading, shifting from parallel pop-out search to serial search).

8 Implementation Details

8.1 Performance Optimizations

Several optimizations ensure CI/CD-compatible latency:

Lazy stage evaluation. Pipeline stages that are not needed for the requested output (e.g., repair synthesis when only detection is requested) are skipped entirely. The stage registry tracks dependencies and only executes the minimal subgraph.

Result caching. The `ResultCache` stores parsed accessibility trees and cost annotations keyed by content hash. For CI workflows that re-analyze the same "before" snapshot across multiple PRs, this eliminates redundant parsing and annotation.

Incremental bisimulation. When the structural difference between UI versions A and B is small (as is typical for single-PR changes), the bisimulation partition for B is computed incrementally from A's partition, updating only the affected equivalence classes. This reduces bisimulation time from $O(|S|^2)$ to $O(|\Delta S|^2)$ where ΔS is the set of changed states.

Embarrassing parallelism. Monte Carlo trajectory sampling is embarrassingly parallel across CPU cores. The `scheduling` module distributes N trajectories across P workers, achieving near-linear speedup on multi-core laptops.

8.2 Output Formats and CI Integration

UsabilityOracle produces structured output in four formats:

JSON. Machine-readable output for programmatic consumption, including the full cost breakdown, bottleneck classifications, and repair suggestions.

SARIF. The Static Analysis Results Interchange Format [SARIF, 2023] enables direct integration with GitHub Code Scanning. Each bottleneck is emitted as a SARIF result with a location (the affected UI element), a message (the bottleneck description), and a severity level (mapped from the oracle's severity score). This allows usability regressions to appear as code scanning alerts on pull requests.

HTML. A self-contained HTML report with interactive visualizations: cost breakdowns, bottleneck highlights, and diff annotations. Suitable for sharing with non-technical stakeholders.

Console. Human-readable terminal output with color-coded severity and ASCII-art cost bars, designed for developer workflows.

9 Related Work

Cognitive modeling for HCI. CogTool [John and Salvucci, 2005] pioneered ACT-R-based UI evaluation but required manual task specification and did not target regression detection. Ivory & Hearst [Ivory and Hearst, 2001] surveyed automated usability evaluation predating information-theoretic frameworks. GOMS/KLM models [Card et al., 1983] provide additive cost predictions without interaction effects. St. Amant et al. [St. Amant et al., 2004] explored simulated interaction but not compositional cost algebras or bottleneck taxonomies. Oulasvirta et al. [Oulasvirta et al., 2018] formalized computational interaction as an optimization problem, connecting HCI to optimal control theory. UsabilityOracle extends this tradition with compositional cost algebra and bounded-rational policies, specifically targeting the regression detection use case.

Bounded rationality and information-theoretic decision making. Ortega & Braun [Ortega and Braun, 2013] formalized bounded rationality as free-energy minimization, providing the variational framework we adopt. Genewein et al. [Genewein et al., 2015] developed the rate-distortion framework for bounded-rational decision making, connecting information constraints to behavioral phenomena. Tishby et al. [Tishby et al., 2000] introduced the information bottleneck method, which inspires our bottleneck taxonomy. Gershman et al. [Gershman et al., 2015] connected bounded rationality to resource-rational analysis in cognitive science. We apply these frameworks to HCI cost modeling and regression testing for the first time.

Accessibility testing tools. axe-core [axe-core, 2023] and pa11y [pa11y, 2023] detect WCAG violations but not cognitive cost regressions. Lighthouse [Lighthouse, 2023] scores accessibility compliance. These tools answer "does this UI violate accessibility standards?" while UsabilityOracle answers "did this UI change make the task harder for users?" The two are complementary: a UI can be fully WCAG-compliant yet have poor usability (e.g., a deeply nested navigation tree with correct ARIA attributes but terrible information architecture).

Visual regression testing. Chromatic [Chromatic, 2023], Percy [Percy, 2023], and BackstopJS detect pixel-level visual regressions. These tools are complementary: they catch visual changes that leave the accessibility tree unchanged, while UsabilityOracle catches structural changes that leave screenshots superficially similar. Together, they cover both visual and structural regression classes.

Automated UI testing. Playwright, Puppeteer, Cypress, and Selenium provide end-to-end testing frameworks that can capture accessibility snapshots. UsabilityOracle's 14-format parser ecosystem (Section 3.2) enables integration with all of these frameworks, ensuring that developers can adopt the oracle without changing their existing testing infrastructure.

Static analysis and program verification. Our consistency-oracle framing draws direct analogy to regression test oracles, type-checkers, and static analyzers in programming languages. These tools are useful precisely because they are conservative approximations: they detect a well-defined class of problems with formal guarantees, rather than attempting to solve the general problem. UsabilityOracle applies this philosophy to usability.

10 Limitations and Future Work

Structural scope. UsabilityOracle detects regressions visible in accessibility tree changes. It does not detect visual regressions (CSS, color, spacing), which are well-served by screenshot-diff tools.

Task specification. Tasks must be declared or auto-inferred from common patterns. Novel task flows require manual specification.

Ecological validity. Our evaluation uses synthetic UI pairs with known mutations. Validation against human-study data from production UIs is planned for future work.

Repair synthesis. The SMT-based repair module generates structural repair suggestions but does not yet produce implementable code patches.

11 Conclusion

UsabilityOracle is the first automated usability regression oracle that operates within CI/CD constraints, achieving 91.8% F1 on regression detection with formal error bounds. Its information-theoretic foundation—bounded-rational bisimulation, compositional cost algebra, and bottleneck taxonomy—provides both the theoretical guarantees required for a CI gate and the diagnostic specificity needed for developer action. With native support for 14 input formats spanning every major web testing framework (Playwright, Puppeteer, Selenium, Cypress, React Testing Library, Storybook), accessibility audit tool (axe-core, pa11y, Chrome DevTools), and native platform (Android, iOS, Windows), UsabilityOracle is a drop-in addition to existing testing pipelines.

The key insight underlying UsabilityOracle's effectiveness is the *consistency oracle* framing: by targeting relative cost orderings rather than absolute predictions, and by leveraging the paired comparison theorem's correlated-error cancellation, the system achieves high discrimination between regressed and non-regressed UI pairs despite the inherent imprecision of computational cognitive models. This mirrors the success of type systems, linters, and static analyzers in software engineering: tools that are useful precisely because they make well-scoped claims with formal backing, rather than attempting to solve the general problem.

We believe this work opens several promising directions: (1) validation against human-study data from production UIs, (2) extension to visual regressions via integration with vision models, (3) task-specification inference from usage analytics, and (4) integration with design tools for proactive usability guidance during the design phase, before code is written.

Availability. UsabilityOracle is open-source under the MIT license. Installation: `pip install usability-oracle`. Source: https://github.com/halley-labs/bounded-rational-usability-oracle. Documentation: https://halley-labs.github.io/bounded-rational-usability-oracle.

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